

ANDYROBERTSEdit

After London it was time to head north to the picturesque North Midlands County of Northamptonshire where I caught up with some of the locals. Travel radio Australia and we're in the Northampton area of England this month and I have with me Andy Roberts and Andy can you tell us a bit about your title and what you do? Yes, I say Andy Roberts. I'm a tourism officer for West Northamptonshire Council obviously tasked with improving the visitor economy for Northampton and the surrounding area.

This area is a wonderful place. It's very close to London. It's only an hour or so drive or an hour and a half drive and very easy to get to if you are coming to London on the train.

And tell us about some of the things you can do and see in the area. Yeah, we think Northampton and the wider county is a bit of a hidden gem really and you say an hour from London and location is probably one of our key strengths here in terms of people visiting the UK and that we're an hour from London and Birmingham, Oxford, Cambridge, Stratford. A good base to come and explore but there's a lot to see and do here in its own right really.

My job is to try and enhance the tourism offer for visitors and locals alike to be fair. And just as an example, we have what I consider several key strengths to Northampton in terms of the offer we can offer around the town's history and heritage. Certainly the town's sporting offer, the green space and the blue space of the canals and the waterside, not least the town and areas shoe industry, which is world famous.

We probably don't shout about it often and long enough, but that's certainly something worth coming here to explore. And we have a good cultural base as well. So there are several good strong elements to Northampton.

We probably don't shout too loud about it. We need to be shouting louder and hopefully that's what we can do in the near future. I noticed there's some really interesting things you can visit.

One of the ones was the Spencer Lady Diana grave area is very close here, isn't it? It is. I mean, Lady Dye, she's known obviously is buried on an island at the Althorpe State, which is a few miles out of Northampton. So that's very close at hand.

I expect another iconic venue that we have in the county is Silverstone Motor Racing Circuit, the home of Formula One, really. We've just had the Grand Prix and Silverstone, again, is only a few miles out of Northampton towards Milton Keynes. So there are two big attractions, really.

I expect the county is traditionally known for its historic houses and the vast array of historic houses and gentry who still live in this county. Althorpe, obviously, is to the fore. But we also have Solgrave Manor, which is the ancestral home of George Washington.

Something slightly a little bit different is there is also an Australian connection and one of the cemeteries in Northampton, really, where a Northampton woman, born in Northampton and also buried in Northampton, but best known for her work as a social reformer, really, in Australia, Caroline Chisholm. And she has a grave in the town. Again, you know, that's something people are very interested in when they come and visit here.

Yes, certainly we have a university named after her in Melbourne and that Chisholm campus there. So she is very well known in Australia and especially in Melbourne. The town itself, I've been spending about a week here and it's very easy to get around.

Lovely. There's a beautiful church in town. Tell us about that.

There are several beautiful churches. I know I'm biased, but I think there are. Yeah, there are some lovely churches really throughout the county.

But certainly in Northampton Town Centre, where we have right in the middle of the town is the All Saints Church, which is a sort of a portico style church with a little cafe right in the heart of Northampton. Just a short walk away is the Church of the Holy Sepulchre, one of only four round churches in England in terms of its design and based on the the original Church of the Holy Sepulchre in Jerusalem, a really interesting building. And also, funnily enough, I had a call today from a lady who's taking over a restaurant in a church, the Church of St John, again, one of the principal town churches, which has been transformed into a very atmospheric and interesting restaurant to visit.

And I noticed, staying here for a week, I got the very easy to buy stagecoach pass, which is like £23 a week, gives you unlimited transport, which is very handy too. Absolutely, yes. I mean, in fairness, Jeff, I'm in public transport in Northampton and in the country generally is a bit of a bone of contention because most people think it could be better, certainly compared to, I'm not sure the situation in Australia, but certainly compared to Europe.

But yeah, there are certainly still some very good deals to get on the buses. The trains are quite expensive, it has to be said, but buses do offer good value on the whole. Tell us a bit more about the Silverstone race experience.

That sounds great. Yes, I mean, a few years ago now, the Silverstone Circuit has really grown and amplified itself, I expect, in recent years. And as part of that, they've opened what they call the Silverstone Museum, which is an experience for the whole family to come along and learn, obviously, about the history of the British Grand Prix and Formula One generally, and the history of motorsport and, you know, the old cars and the old gear that they used to wear.

And it's a very interactive experience. It's called the Silverstone Museum, to say it's based next to the circuit. It's a great day out for families.

So if you are in this area and looking to test your motor, motorsport skills, that's certainly a place to, you need to go to. And I believe there's a simulator there too, where you can just jump into and act like you really are Louis Hamilton or someone like... You can change a tyre in the pit lane and what have you and see how quick you are. So for kids especially, it's brilliant.

And what's your one of your favourite go-to places? I expect, because I'm of a certain age now, I'm getting to appreciate the countryside, really. Again, we have some beautiful countryside in Northamptonshire, certainly in the south of the county, which takes on a Cotswolds feel. And they say it's a bit like the Cotswolds, but without the traffic and the people really, some beautiful villages.

And I expect one of my favourite areas is a little place called Foursley, which is near the town of Daventree. A beautiful green rolling landscape, very tranquil, very peaceful place, which hasn't changed really over the years, designed by Capability Brown. It's got one hotel and one little restaurant, but the rest is just sheep and beauty really.

So that's my go-to place just to chill out. Sounds wonderful. Well, thanks very much for telling us all about the wonderful area of Northampton and indeed Northamptonshire.

Is it a county or...? It is, yes. Again, just finally, Northamptonshire, they have a cricket team, played Australia a few times over the years, not to great success. But obviously a good sports space in the town as well with football and not least, we've got to get this in, the English champions of Rugby Northampton Saints.

And you have a really nice stadium here too. Tell us a bit about that. Yeah, that would be the Saints Stadium I think you refer to, which is a great rugby venue.

It's one of the venues for the Women's Rugby World Cup next year. So if anyone's coming over, do visit Northampton on your travels as part of that and see the sights. Yeah, so that's a top class facility.

We're very proud of our rugby team. And Andy, how can people find out more about Northamptonshire in general online? Yeah, I mean, we're in the process of obviously through the local authority here getting a greater online presence. But I think the best there are two go-tos I expect online.

If you search Discover Northamptonshire, it's a website dedicated to what's on around the wider county. And also there's something called Northamptonshire's best surprise, which if you that brings up all the attractions we have here and all the information about when they're open and what there is to do and see. So Discover Northamptonshire or Northamptonshire's big surprise.

Andy Roberts, thank you very much for being with us on Travel Radio Australia. Pleasure. Many thanks for sparing me your time to talk about Northhans.

Thank you.